

growing gremlin of financial stress and anxiety with kind questions, curiosity about what she truly wanted, and smart steps toward those goals. This process made it possible for Christine to validate her anxiety, to see it as a warning light illuminating very real economic and individual concerns, while also coming up with a plan. The plan Christine made was connected to the things she found most important. She quickly discovered that she didn't care to buy a house anytime soon, so setting aside money for that goal was not important to her. And instead of Instagram-perfect resort experiences, she preferred camping in the woods. Once she cut out the things she didn't love, her money could go toward paying off credit card debt with room for the occasional takeout dinner and weekend trip. The more Christine learned about herself, the more she was able to tailor her spending and financial goals to what she truly wanted. And the more closely her plan reflected who she was, the more confident she felt about her finances.

Before we get to the type of curiosity that made these big shifts possible for Christine, we want to acknowledge the path to curiosity that's most common but often misguided: personality tests. The internet is full of gimmicks like: "Take this 5-min quiz to see what Disney princess you are," or "Look at these photos to determine if you're a bacon-wrapped shrimp or a pistachio-topped ice cream cone." (I made that last one up but can't say I wouldn't engage in that questionnaire!) I'm not throwing shade at these fun little quizzes, it's just that they don't actually help us in meaningful ways. It's recognizing our desire and need to know more about who we are but addressing it with fictional characters and personified food.

Beyond the trite quizzes, there are more in-depth personality tests like the Enneagram, Myers-Briggs, and DiSC. While these questionnaires are certainly more helpful than knowing if you're a bacon-wrapped shrimp, they won't provide the full picture needed to find what you value spending on. We are drawn to these tests because we ultimately want to understand ourselves, how we function, what makes us tick, how we are set apart from one another, and what makes us similar to others. What's more, we want to feel seen and understood. Ask anyone who has taken even just a short swim in the personality test pool and their eyes will light up with tales of their number or letter combination! Most can spend at least five minutes regaling us of the pros and cons of their unique internal makeup, what they enjoy and don't enjoy, how they do or don't mesh with their significant other, and